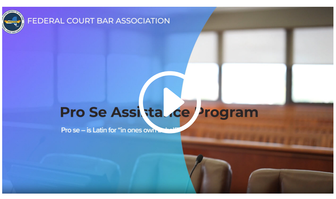
Pro Se Assistance Program

Watch the video for an overview of the Pro Se Assistance Program and the services we provide.

Scroll down to see information about our "Pro Se Pal" AI bot, which functions as a virtual assistant, available 24/7 to answer questions and guide users through legal procedures. Simply click the "Let's Chat" bubble to begin.

See All Program Videos



Representing Yourself In Federal Court

If you wish to file a civil action in federal court but do not have an attorney to represent you, you may bring your case on your own. **This is called "*proceeding pro se*," which means that you are representing yourself in the Court, and you are called a "*pro se litigant*."**

A civil case, which is the only type of case you can file in federal court, is different from a criminal case, which can only be brought by government officials. In a civil case, you do not have a constitutional right to appointed counsel. Therefore, if you file a civil case pro se, you should be prepared to pursue it to completion on your own because the Court appoints counsel only under certain limited circumstances that may not be met by your case. **The Pro Se Assistance Program is limited to individuals who are representing themselves in civil lawsuits in the Northern District of New York. We cannot assist incarcerated individuals or those who are currently in psychiatric facilities.** See "Who does the Pro Se Assistance Program Serve" below for more information.

If you are an incarcerated individual looking for assistance, please visit our Pro Se Referral Guide for program referrals that can assist you.

Before you file your case, you should read the Pro Se Handbook. You should also read the Local Rules of Practice for the Northern District of New York so that you are familiar with the procedural rules that you must follow throughout your lawsuit, including the Consequences for Failing to Respond to a Motion for Summary Judgment. Finally, you should become familiar with the forms made available to you by the Court. *The Clerk's Office can provide you with procedural assistance but may not provide legal advice.* See the Pro Se Notice.

Who does the Pro Se Assistance Program Serve?

The NDNY Federal Court Bar Association, Inc. established the **Pro Se Assistance Program** to assist litigants who are representing themselves in federal court with preparing and drafting their papers in support or defense of a civil action in the Northern District of New York.

Due to program limitations, we are unable to provide assistance to individuals who are currently incarcerated or to accept calls from correctional or psychiatric facilities. In addition, the Program does not handle criminal matters or appeals.

Individuals seeking assistance with criminal cases, appeals, or matters arising from incarceration are encouraged to contact the appropriate legal services organizations or court-appointed counsel resources.

Areas Served

- Syracuse
- Albany
- Binghamton
- Utica
- Plattsburgh
- Watertown

The services offered by The Pro Se Assistance Program are free of charge. There are certain court costs associated with filing or defending a lawsuit in Federal Court. The Pro Se Assistance Program will not pay any of these costs.

Use of the Pro Se Assistance Program is entirely separate from any appointment of counsel by the Court. A request for appointment of counsel requires submission of a separate application and the decision whether to appoint counsel is entirely within the Court's discretion.

What services will the Pro Se Coordinator Provide?

The Pro Se Coordinator is a qualified attorney who will assist pro se litigants (individuals who are representing themselves in a federal court action), by providing necessary information and assistance in the initiation or defense of a civil lawsuit filed in the Northern District, including:

- Information about federal court procedures
- Assistance in the preparation of pleadings and other court documents
- Consultation relating to discovery and motion practice
- Assistance in accessing additional information and/or research about your legal issues
- Referrals to other services, in appropriate cases

Is the Pro Se Coordinator my Attorney?

Although the Pro Se Coordinator is a qualified attorney, he/she is NOT your attorney. The Pro Se Coordinator will not:

- Appear in court on your behalf
- Research, write, or file court documents for you
- Conduct any investigation into the facts of your case
- Negotiate with your opponent or your opponent's attorney

Because the Pro Se Coordinator is not your attorney, your communications with the Pro Se Coordinator are not subject to attorney-client privilege. However, we will not voluntarily disclose any information about your case to anyone else.

What should I have prepared when I speak with the Pro Se Coordinator?

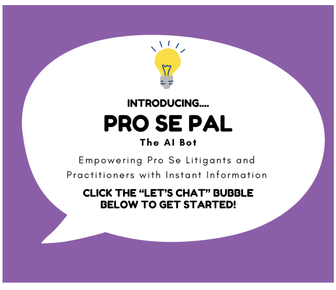
In order for the Pro Se Coordinator to best assist you, you should have access the following:

- Any pleadings or other court documents that have already been filed and/or you have already begun drafting
- Any documents related to your case that you want the Pro Se Coordinator to review

It is very important that you give the Pro Se Coordinator your full cooperation, and you must answer any questions that the Pro Se Coordinator asks you truthfully and to the best of your knowledge.

You can find more information in our Pro Se Assistance Program Brochure (PDF) and on the U.S. District Court for the Northern District of New York Website, where you can download the Pro Se Handbook, the Local Rules, and any required forms.

You can reach the Pro Se Program by calling (315) 422-2711 or by emailing our Pro Se Inbox here.



The NDNY Federal Court Bar Association, Inc. established the Pro Se Assistance Program in an effort to address the varying needs of pro se litigants, to help pro se litigants better understand the complexities involved in the prosecution or defense of a legal action, and to assist the Northern District of New York in the administration of justice. **If you are a Pro Se Litigant looking for assistance, please call 315-422-2711 or email prose [at] ndnyfcba.org. You may also find answers to your questions from our new "Pro Se Pal" AI bot. Simply click the "Let's Chat" bubble in the lower right-hand corner of this page to get started.**

How the "Pro Se Pal" AI Bot Works

The "Pro Se Pal" AI bot functions as a virtual assistant, available 24/7 to answer questions and guide users through legal procedures. You can ask questions, and the bot will direct you to relevant information and resources. The Pro Se Pal cannot give you legal advice, but it can help you more easily navigate legal issues. It can also help you with the preparation and drafting of papers in support or defense of a civil action in the Northern District of New York.

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The NDNY-FCBA is not a court of law or part of the U.S. District Court for the Northern District of New York. The Court's web site can be found at www.nynd.uscourts.gov.

NDNY-FCBA thanks Staff Leasing and Dannil McKee for their continued support.

Let's Chat